



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 18/01/26	Entry: 1
Description	This journal entry documents a ransomware incident that occurred at a small U.S. health care clinic, which caused major disruptions to business operations and prevented access to critical patient data.
Tool(s) used	No cybersecurity tools were used at the time of the incident. External technical assistance and incident response support were later contacted.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. Who caused the incident? The incident was caused by an organized threat actor group known for targeting organizations in the healthcare and transportation industries. What happened? All company files were encrypted by ransomware, and a ransom note was displayed demanding payment in exchange for a decryption key. Employees were unable to access medical records or essential software.

	When did the incident occur? The incident occurred on a Tuesday at approximately 9:00 a.m. Where did the incident happen? The incident took place at the office of a small U.S. health care clinic. Why did the incident happen? The incident occurred due to a phishing attack. An employee downloaded a malicious email attachment, which allowed ransomware to be installed and deployed across the network.
Additional notes	Without the decryption key, all patient data remains inaccessible and may be permanently lost. This incident highlights the critical need for phishing awareness training, regular data backups, and stronger email security controls.

Date: 20/01/26	Entry: 2
Description	An employee received an email containing a password-protected spreadsheet attachment. The password to open the file was included in the email. When the employee opened the spreadsheet, malicious code was injected and executed on the system. The file was immediately retrieved and hashed using the SHA-256 algorithm. SHA-256: 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b

Tool(s) used	VirusTotal was used to scan the file and uncover indicators of compromise.
The 5 W's	Who caused the incident? A threat actor caused the incident by sending a malicious spreadsheet via email. What happened? When the file was opened, malicious code was injected and executed on the employee's computer. When did the incident occur? The incident occurred at approximately 1:15 p.m. Where did the incident happen? On an employee's workstation within the organization. Why did the incident happen? The threat actor injected malicious code to gain unauthorized access to the system.
Additional notes	The file was password-protected, which is notable because this technique can help malware bypass security controls and appear more legitimate to the user.

Date: 20/01/26	Entry: 3
Description	An alert was raised for a suspected phishing attempt. The email was sent from Def Communications with the sender domain <76tguyhh6tgftrt7tg.su>

	and originating IP address <114.114.114.114>. The email contained a password-protected executable file attachment.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal was used to scan the file and uncover indicators of compromise.
The 5 W's	Who caused the incident? The incident was caused by a threat actor impersonating an individual named Clyde West. What happened? A phishing email was sent containing a password-protected executable file. The email included multiple grammatical errors and provided the password needed to open the attachment. When did the incident occur? July 20, 2022, at 09:30:14 AM. Where did the incident happen? On an employee's workstation within the organization. Why did the incident happen? The threat actor attempted to deliver malicious code to gain unauthorized access to the system.
Additional notes	The attachment was password-protected, which is a common technique used to bypass email security controls and make the file appear legitimate. The password provided in the email was paradise10789 .

Date: 20/01/26	Entry: 4
Description	An employee received an email claiming that customer data had been stolen and demanding payment to prevent public disclosure. The employee initially assumed the message was spam and deleted it. A follow-up email was later received containing a sample of stolen customer data and an increased ransom demand. The employee then reported the incident to the security team. Investigation revealed a vulnerability in the organization's e-commerce web application that allowed unauthorized access to customer data.
Tool(s) used	No security tools were initially involved. The investigation later included analysis of web server access logs by the security team.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. Who caused the incident? An external threat actor exploited a vulnerability in the organization's e-commerce web application. What happened? Customer personally identifiable information (PII) and transaction data were accessed without authorization through a forced browsing attack. The attacker attempted to extort the organization by demanding cryptocurrency payments. When did the incident occur? Initial compromise occurred on December 22, 2022, at 3:13 p.m. PT. The incident was confirmed and escalated on December 28, 2022. Where did the incident happen? The incident occurred within the organization's e-commerce web application hosted on its web server. Why did the incident happen?

	The web application lacked proper access controls, allowing attackers to manipulate URL parameters and access unauthorized purchase confirmation pages containing customer PII.
Additional notes	The threat actor increased the ransom demand after receiving no response. Approximately 50,000 customer records were affected.

Reflections/Notes:

These incidents show how often phishing is used as the starting point for attacks. Employees opening malicious, password-protected attachments played a major role in multiple cases. This highlights the need for better phishing awareness training and stricter email security controls.

The ransomware incident shows how damaging attacks can be when backups and response plans are not in place. Losing access to critical data can completely disrupt business operations, especially in healthcare.

The use of tools like VirusTotal was helpful in identifying malicious files quickly. This reinforces the importance of threat intelligence during investigations.

Overall, these cases show that both human error and technical weaknesses can lead to serious security incidents, and prevention depends on user awareness, monitoring, and proper security controls.